In Step

Our new link — what changes for you, in plain English

A proposal for discussion · CEA link from 1 January 2027 · 26 weeks · code IS-26-T4

The short version

Five things to take away if you remember nothing else

35h	5	14	9 of 15	30 min
the contracted week, as now	**most days in a row**	**full weekends off a year**	**shift times you already work**	**off every closing shift**
no extra hours	up to 7 · today 7–9	today 10 · 7 in 26	6 new ones	up to 1 hour

Same hours, shorter closers, weekends off never more than five weeks apart, and never more than five days in a row, cover weeks aside.

Why the link has to change

Nobody is changing it for the sake of it

A new timetable in December 2026

More trains, at new times — the new link follows from 1 January 2027.

More of us on the link

It grows from 20 weeks to 26, so six more colleagues join it.

New staffing levels

At least 10 on a Sunday, and more at the close and at 22:00. We also aim for 14 on a Saturday.

The ticket office in fixed pairs

Two early and two late, on the same shifts, every day.

The change is coming whatever we do — the question is which version we want.

Will I work more?

The first thing everyone asks

	Today	In Step
Contracted hours a week	35h	**35h**
Contracted days at work a week	4.20	**4.19**
Contracted days at work a year	219.0	**218.6**

No. The same 35-hour week on average; weeks run 25h 30m–41h 05m Monday to Saturday (today 25h 10m–43h 50m), and two more days a year are Saturdays.

Will my basic pay change?

Basic pay follows your contracted hours — and a swap for a late earns less overtime

	Today	In Step
Contracted hours a week	35h	**35h**
Saturdays a year, at time and a quarter	26	**28**
Sunday overtime to share — each, a year	21	**20**
A late against an early, same day, on average	32 min longer	**11 min shorter**
Finishing at 13:35 or 13:45 — each, a year	26	**12**

No: basic pay stays the same. Premium and overtime pay come to about £250 a year less, gross, if you work your share of Sundays. That assumes no swap overtime.

Will my shifts be longer?

Closing shifts get shorter, earlies longer — the average goes up about two minutes

	Today	In Step
Weekday closer — starts 15:45, not 15:15	8h 40m	**8h 10m**
Saturday closer — starts 15:45, not 14:45	9h 10m	**8h 10m**
Sunday closer — starts 15:15, not 14:30	8h 55m	**8h 10m**
Average early, Monday to Saturday	7h 59m	**8h 21m**
Average late, Monday to Saturday	8h 29m	**8h 10m**
Average shift, Monday to Saturday	8h 14m	**8h 16m**

Every closing shift is 30 to 60 minutes shorter; the longest early Monday to Saturday goes from 8h 30m to 8h 55m, and nothing runs over 9 hours.

Will I finish late more often?

3 more a year at 23:00 or later (42, today 39); 16 more at 22:00 or later (94, today 78)

	Today	In Step
Finishing at 23:00 or later — each, a year	39	**42**
Finishing at 22:00 or later — each, a year	78	**94**
Starting at 06:20 — each, a year	62	**60**
Shortest gap between two shifts	12h 30m	**14h 35m**

More people stay on after 22:00 under the December staffing; the three more at 23:00 or later are the fewest the rules allow.

Will I know the times?

15 shift times in all — 9 of them you already work

You work these today (9)

06:20–13:35
06:20–13:45
06:20–14:20
06:20–14:50
07:15–15:45
08:00–16:30
12:00–20:00
14:00–22:30
14:30–22:00

New times (6)

- Closers start later: 30 minutes on weekdays, an hour on Saturdays, 45 minutes on Sundays
- Two longer weekday earlies, 06:20–15:15 and 07:00–15:45, and a new late, 14:30–22:30
- On Sundays: a 9-hour early, 09:00–18:00, and the ticket-office late, 14:30–22:30

Fewer shift times than today (15, not 18) — and on a Saturday only the closer is new.

Rest and weekends

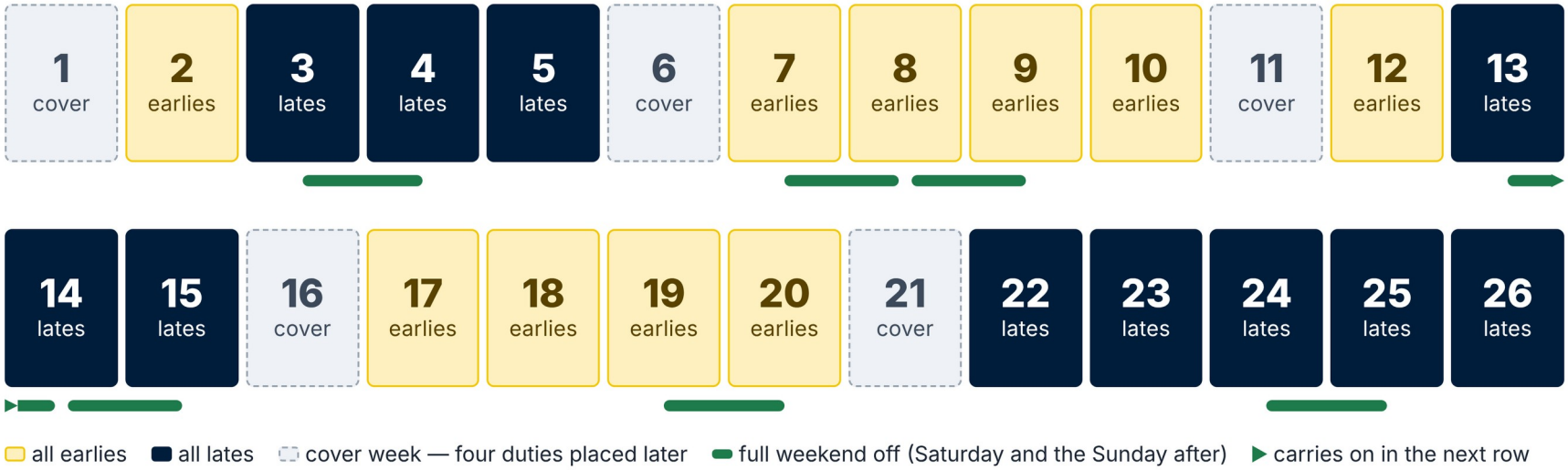
The biggest improvement over today

	Today	In Step
Full weekends off, about a year	10	**14**
Most days worked in a row	7 (up to 9)	**5 (up to 7)**
Rest-day breaks of two days or more	13 of 17	**22 of 26**
Shortest gap between two shifts	12h 30m	**14h 35m**
Weeks on one shift time, Monday to Friday	7 of 16	**18 of 21**

14 full weekends off a year, at most five weeks apart, and never more than five days in a row, cover weeks aside.

Your 26 weeks at a glance

The green bars are the full weekends off; where you start is decided later



Blocks of earlies or lates up to 5 weeks, 7 if the cover weeks go the same way; a full weekend off comes round at least every 5 weeks.

Booking leave

What 14 days of annual leave buys you, with Sundays off

	Today	In Step
Days off in a row — best place to book	30	**28**
Days off in a row — on average	23.4	**23.4**
Days off in a row — worst place	19	**20**
Leave for four full weeks off, at best	14	**15**

Best stretch 28 days, not 30; four full weeks off in a row, Sunday to Saturday, costs 15 days' leave, not 14. Average the same, worst a day better.

More staff on the floor

More people rostered every day, and more at the open and the close on most days

	Today	In Step
On duty on a weekday	11–12	**15**
On duty on a Saturday / Sunday	10 / 8	**14 / 10**
Fewest rostered on the floor	2	**3**
Avoidable fatigue warnings, cover weeks aside	4 (up to 5)	**0 (up to 1)**

At least three rostered on the floor, and no avoidable fatigue warnings, cover weeks aside.

The honest trade-offs

Nothing is free — here is what it costs

Six new shift times to learn

Three shorter lates, two longer weekday earlies and the 9-hour Sunday early.

Earlies or lates in longer runs

Up to 5 weeks of one kind, 7 if the cover weeks go the same way (today 2, up to 3).

Four weeks off: 15 days' leave, not 14

The least leave for four complete weeks off in a row, Sunday to Saturday.

Two more Saturdays a year

28 a year each, today 26 — fourteen on a Saturday, shared across 26 lines.

More late finishes

42 a year each at 23:00 or later (today 39), and 94 at 22:00 or later (today 78).

Fewer early finishes

12 a year each finish before 14:00 (today 26).

None of these is hidden: every figure here is worked out from the rota.

At a glance

Same hours and days, shorter closers, more weekends off, fewer days in a row

	Today	In Step
Contracted hours a week	35h	35h
Contracted days at work a year	219.0	218.6
Average shift · longest shift	8h 14m · 9h 10m	8h 16m · 9h 00m
Closing shift: weekday · Saturday · Sunday	8h 40m · 9h 10m · 8h 55m	**8h 10m · 8h 10m · 8h 10m**
Full weekends off, about a year	10	**14**
Most days worked in a row	7 (up to 9)	**5 (up to 7)**
Shortest gap between two shifts	12h 30m	14h 35m
Different shift times	18	15 (9 you know)
On duty weekday · Saturday · Sunday	11–12 · 10 · 8	15 · 14 · 10
Avoidable fatigue warnings, cover weeks aside	4 (up to 5)	0 (up to 1)

The costs: more late finishes and longer runs of earlies or lates.



What happens next

1. Look at the full proposal sheet — page 3 shows every week of the link
2. Tell us what worries you, even if it is small
3. Your feedback goes to the managers with the proposal